

UX Engine - "Do This, Not That" Playbook

A compilation of UX/UI design decisions extracted from the UX Engine reel series, formatted as direct, actionable rules.

1. Reverse-Engineered: Linear

DON'T use loose, airy layouts that waste screen space.

DO use **high density** (13px text, 32px rows) to signal professional competence.

DON'T rely on drop shadows to create depth in dark mode.

DO use **1px alpha borders (8% white)** and varied background lightness values.

DON'T center all text and icons indiscriminately.

DO center icons, **left-align labels**, and **right-align numbers**.

2. Responsive Data Tables

DON'T blindly shrink a desktop table or force horizontal scrolling.

DO restructure it: **stack data** (name/amount on top, status below) into two lines per row.

DON'T label obvious things (like a dollar amount).

DO label **ambiguous data** (like dates, e.g. "Due Mar 04").

DON'T open new pages to show row details on mobile.

DO **expand records in place** using a slide-down sheet.

3. UI Numbers

DON'T use default proportional fonts for columns of numbers; they will wobble.
DO use **tabular figures (tabular-nums)** so digits lock to the same exact width.

DON'T show massive trailing zeros by default (e.g. 3,400,000).
DO **abbreviate big numbers** (e.g. 3.4M) and show full precision only on hover.

DON'T include the currency symbol inside the aligned number column.
DO **pin the currency symbol to the left** of the column and align the decimals.

4. Dark Mode is a System

DON'T use pure black (#000000) for the background; it kills depth.
DO use **near-black** so you can raise elements by lightening their background.

DON'T use pure white text, which causes eye fatigue.
DO use **three opacity tiers of white** (87% Primary, 60% Secondary, 38% Disabled).

DON'T leave photos and illustrations at full brightness.
DO **dim photos to 90%** brightness and draw true dark variants for illustrations.

5. Drag Handles / Split Views

DON'T make the interactive hit area as thin as the visual line (1px).
DO **grow the invisible grab zone** to at least 12px wide.

DON'T let users drag a panel until it's a broken, unopenable 1px sliver.

DO clamp the drag limits and snap the panel fully closed near the edge.

DON'T let iframes or text selection interrupt the mouse while dragging.

DO drop an invisible overlay across the whole page mid-drag.

6. System Coherence

DON'T let screens be designed in isolation, inventing new colors or spacing values.

DO enforce a centralized token system to prevent UI drift across the product.

DON'T silently bypass the design system when you need a custom style.

DO document exceptions explicitly or map them to the closest existing token.

7. Avatar Component System

DON'T ever show a broken image square if an avatar fails to load.

DO degrade gracefully from Image → Initials → Generic Icon.

DON'T use a single initial (unless tiny), as it reads like a bug.

DO show **two initials (first and last)** and deterministically generate the background color based on the name.

DON'T place a separate status dot next to the avatar.

DO wrap the avatar in a **colored presence ring** to reduce redundancy.

8. Scroll Position / Routing

DON'T dump users at scroll position 0 on back navigation in a single-page app.

DO save and restore the exact scroll position linked to the history state.

DON'T let restored scroll positions or anchor links hide underneath a sticky header.

DO use **scroll-margin-top** on headings to account for the header's height.

DON'T put important links (Terms, Contact) in a footer below an infinite scroll feed.

DO move them elsewhere, as **users will never reach the bottom**.

9. Touch vs Hover Interactions

DON'T let mobile browsers trigger "sticky hovers" on the first tap.

DO guard hover CSS with **@media (hover: hover)**.

DON'T hide primary actions purely behind hover states.

DO ensure hidden actions have a **permanent, accessible home on mobile** (e.g. swipe to reveal).

DON'T make tap targets the exact size of a 16px icon.

DO **pad the invisible bounding box** to at least 44px for clumsy thumbs.

10. Pull to Refresh

DON'T use a 1:1 linear drag that feels cheap.

DO add **elastic resistance** and require pulling past a physical threshold.

DON'T abruptly swap states or freeze the list during the reload.

DO **seamlessly morph** the stretch indicator into the spinner, and keep the scroll active.

11. Radius (Corners)

DON'T make inner and outer corners the exact same radius if there is padding.

DO calculate mathematically: **Inner Radius = Outer Radius - Padding**.

DON'T apply corner radius to an element touching the absolute screen edge.

DO set edge-touching corners to **0px**.

12. State (Disable)

DON'T let users tap a submit button twice on a slow connection.

DO **instantly disable the button** on the first tap.

DON'T let the layout jump when swapping text for a loading spinner.

DO **lock the exact width** of the button before showing the spinner.

DON'T vanish the button immediately on success.

DO morph to a checkmark and **hold for a beat** to provide clear feedback.

13. One line of CSS (Zero JS)

DON'T use JavaScript to style a parent card based on a checked radio inside.

DO use the modern CSS **:has()** selector (e.g. `.card:has(:checked)`).

DON'T rely on React state to outline invalid inputs in red.

DO use **.field:has(:user-invalid)** to style borders and labels natively.

14. Badge (Unread count)

DON'T let counts grow infinitely (e.g. 14,502) and break layouts.

DO **cap the count** at 99+ to maintain a stable shape.

DON'T show a red number and a green dot on the same row.

DO pick **exactly one signal** per row to avoid visual noise.

DON'T badge every single notification in the app.

DO only badge notifications that require an **actual user decision**.

15. Copy to Clipboard

DON'T use a loading spinner or delay for a local clipboard copy.

DO flip the icon to a checkmark the **exact instant** it fires.

DON'T leave the checkmark stuck forever, or rely purely on visual changes.

DO auto-reset after 2 seconds, and announce "Copied" via an **aria-live** region.

16. Data Table Styling

DON'T zebra-stripe every row, which creates unnecessary noise.

DO use **1px borders** and a hover state instead.

DON'T leave cells blank if data is missing.

DO use a **dash** so the cell isn't a question mark.

DON'T clutter the table with action icons repeated on every row.

DO hide actions behind a kebab menu revealed on hover or focus.

17. Table Row Selection

DON'T make the "select all" checkbox a simple binary toggle.

DO ensure it supports checked, empty, and a **partial dash state**.

DON'T use a heavy confirmation modal for bulk actions (like deleting 200 rows).

DO run the action immediately and offer a **10-second undo toast**.

18. De-Clutter your UI

DON'T use arbitrary gradients across headers or pastel colors for metric tiles.

DO use a **single flat accent color** for meaning, and let the primary number be the hero.

DON'T use generic copy ("Welcome back") or massive drop shadows on everything.

DO use precise dates, **tight radiuses**, and reserve shadows only for floating modals.